PRAETORIAN FITNESS

Launch plan

From concept to first drop · United States · Men's first

Prepared by Plantworks Studio for James · October 2026

The brand: understated, smart, high-end men's fitness wear that works in the gym and socially. Lululemon men's is the reference point. Men's first, women's later. CEO James, Houston, Texas. Launching in the USA.

The model: not print-on-demand dropshipping. Print-on-demand puts a logo on a stock blank, which is merch, not premium. Instead:

1. Small production runs (50–300 per style per colour) from a low-minimum manufacturer.
2. Pre-orders on the site before each run ("Drop 01 ships in 6 weeks"), so customers part-fund production.
3. A 3PL (outsourced warehouse) holds the stock and ships every order. James never packs a box.
4. Restock what sells, drop what doesn't. Launch in limited "drops".

Who does what: Plantworks (Dan) handles the website, shop, brand presentation and socials setup, and is helping with the start-up steps below.

Job list

Owner: **J** = James, **D** = Dan, **J+D** = together.

Phase 1: foundations (weeks 1–2)

- ☐ **J+D** Sit down in Houston and agree this plan, the first range and the budget.
- ☐ **J** Trademark search: USPTO Trademark Search for "Praetorian" in **Class 25** (clothing) and Class 35 (online retail). Note: a UK application for **PRAETORIAN FIGHT WEAR** (Class 25) was filed 30 Dec 2025. It doesn't block the US, but matters if the brand ever sells in the UK. A trademark attorney's clearance search (a few hundred dollars) is worth it before spending on labels and stock.
- ☐ **J** File the US trademark if clear (USPTO fee roughly $350 per class).
- ☐ **J** Texas LLC, EIN, business bank account.

- [ ] J Apply for an **RN number** from the FTC (free, US businesses only). It goes on every garment label in place of the company name.
- [ ] J Buy the domain (`praetorianfitness.com` or similar).
- [ ] D Claim the handles: Instagram, TikTok, Facebook, Pinterest, the same name everywhere.
- [ ] J Pick **one** logo. The concept images show two: a minimal helmet-crest line mark and a shield-with-helmet badge. Get it redrawn as a vector (SVG/AI/PDF).

Phase 2: design to factory-ready (weeks 2–5)

- [ ] J+D Choose the first range: **3 or 4 core pieces in 2 or 3 colours.** Suggested: training tee, shorts, quarter-zip, joggers; black, navy, stone. Caps, shaker and duffel come later.
- [ ] J Hire a freelance **technical designer** (Upwork, Maker's Row, or fashion-school graduates) to make a **tech pack** per style: flat drawings, measurements and size grading (S–XXL), fabric spec, trims, stitching, logo and label placement. Roughly a few hundred dollars per style. Factories can't quote properly without it.
- [ ] J Fabric direction for the technical designer: what makes it premium. Weight, stretch, hand-feel, anti-odour or moisture-wicking finish. Buy one Lululemon and one Vuori piece he likes and send them as the quality reference.
- [ ] J Labels and trims spec:
- [ ] Woven neck label (or printed heat-transfer label for a tagless feel on activewear).
- [ ] Care and content label. US law requires fibre content (generic names, by weight), country of origin, and the company name or RN, plus care instructions (Care Labeling Rule).
- [ ] Hang tags, poly bags, mailer boxes or bags, tissue, thank-you card.

Phase 3: suppliers and samples (weeks 4–12)

- [ ] J+D Contact 8–10 manufacturers from the list below with the tech packs. Ask every one the questions in "What to ask a factory".
- [ ] J Shortlist 3. Order samples from all three (expect $50–300 per sample, sometimes credited against the first order).
- [ ] J+D Judge samples side by side against the reference pieces: fabric, fit, seams, how it washes (wash each sample 5 times).
- [ ] J Second sample round with the chosen factory to fix fit and details. Then sign off a **production sample** ("gold seal") that the run must match.
- [ ] J Order labels and packaging to arrive at the factory before production.

Phase 4: shop and audience (in parallel, from week 2)

- [ ] D Keep the current concept site live as a waitlist (form already built). Remove `noindex` once the domain is live and the name is cleared.
- [ ] D Build the shop on **Shopify** with the current design as a custom theme: product pages with size and colour variants, size guide, pre-orders, discount codes, US sales tax, returns policy.
- [ ] J Stripe/Shopify Payments account in the LLC's name.
- [ ] J Policies: returns and exchanges (30 days is normal for premium), shipping, privacy, terms.

- [ ] **D** Socials: start posting before launch. Fabric close-ups, sketches, samples arriving, the Houston base. Understated, like the brand. No discount-shouting.
- [ ] **J+D** Photography once production samples arrive: product on white (front, back, detail) and a lifestyle set that shows both sides of the brand, the gym and a dinner or coffee setting.

Phase 5: launch (around weeks 12–20)

- [ ] **J** Place the first production run, sized from waitlist interest.
- [ ] **D** Open pre-orders to the waitlist first (24–48 hours early), then public.
- [ ] **J** Set up the **3PL**. Ship the run straight from the factory to the 3PL.
- [ ] **J+D** After launch: track which sizes and colours sell, reorder winners, plan Drop 02. Women's line once men's is proven.

Potential suppliers

Every name below needs checking. These came from a web search on 10 Oct 2026. Most of the sources are manufacturers' own marketing or listicles written by competitors, so minimum orders and prices are what they advertise, not verified. Get written quotes and samples before committing to anyone.

Directories (where to find and compare factories)

- **Maker's Row**: US manufacturer directory with a low-MOQ guide. https://makersrow.com/blog/low-moq-clothing-manufacturer/
- **Sewport**: global manufacturer marketplace.
- **Alibaba**: huge choice, but heavy vetting needed (verified suppliers, trade assurance, samples first). Best left until he knows exactly what he wants.

Los Angeles cut-and-sew (US-made, a short flight from Houston, can visit in person)

Name	What they advertise	Notes
American Apparel Manufacturing (AAM)	Performance fabrics and moisture-wicking knits; about 100 units per style	Most activewear-focused of the LA results
The Evans Group (Tegmade)	Cut and sew since 2005; small batches for emerging designers	Good fit for a premium, design-led line; MOQ not published
Full Speed 100	Published tiers: simple knits 50–100 per style per colour; technical activewear 200–300	Honest about technical minimums being higher
Lefty Production Co.	Around 50 units per style; pattern-making to packing in-house	Basics and streetwear focus; check activewear capability
Los Angeles Apparel	Large vertical factory; one listing says from 25 units per style	Built for scale; confirm small-run terms directly

Name	What they advertise	Notes
Indie Source / Plucky Reach	Around 50 pieces	Plucky Reach is a sourcing network rather than one factory

Sources: Maker's Row, Thygesen Apparel LA list, Full Speed 100, Plucky Reach.

Portugal (premium European knitwear, sensible minimums, often better value than LA)

Name	What they advertise	Notes
Athleisure Basics	60–90 pieces per style per colour; premium blanks with custom branding; 3–5 weeks after approval	Blanks-plus-branding is a faster, cheaper first drop than full custom
Portugal Textile	Premium activewear since 2007; private label from 100 pieces; around 7 weeks	
ASBX (Barcelos)	Jersey/fitness specialist; often 50–100 per style or colour	
Gym Clothes (Portugal)	Sportswear for startups and private label; low MOQs	No numbers published

Sources: Athleisure Basics, Portugal Textile, ASBX, Gym Clothes.

Importing from Portugal to the US adds duty and shipping; ask each factory for a landed-cost estimate (DDP) to Texas.

Labels and tags

Name	What they advertise	Notes
Super Label Store	Woven labels from 5 pieces; care labels and hang tags from 100 (per design)	Published price list
Artco Textiles (New Jersey)	Woven and printed labels, hang tags, since 1981; US facilities	Confirm current minimums

Most label makers start at 500–1,000 pieces, so low minimums are the exception. Many factories can also source labels for you; ask.

Sources: Super Label Store, ApparelSearch label directory.

Fulfilment (3PL)

Name	What's reported	Notes
ShipMonk	$0 setup, around $250/month minimum	Often recommended for under 400 orders a month
ShipBob	Around $275/month minimum, setup fee reported up to $975	Better at higher volume

Neither publishes a rate card; get quotes. Both are expensive under about 200 orders a month, so for the very first drop a **local Houston fulfilment company**, or James shipping the first pre-orders himself, may be cheaper. Move to a 3PL once volume justifies it. Comparison tool: fulfill.com.

Sources: ShipCalm guide, fulfill.com ShipBob vs ShipMonk.

Not recommended for the core range

Printful, Printify and other print-on-demand services: fine later for low-risk extras (a cap, a gym towel), never for the core garments.

What to ask a factory

1. Minimum order per style, per colour, and per size breakdown?
2. Price per unit at 100, 300 and 500 pieces? What's included (fabric, trims, labels, packing)?
3. Sample cost and turnaround? Is the sample cost credited against the first order?
4. Production lead time after sample approval?
5. Fabric: do you stock performance fabrics, or source to our spec? Minimum fabric order?
6. Can you supply and attach our woven labels, care labels and hang tags?
7. Who makes the patterns and grading, and do we own them?
8. Quality control: what's checked before shipping, and what happens with defects?
9. Payment terms (deposit and balance)?
10. Brands you currently make for, and can we see their pieces or speak to one?
11. Shipping: FOB or delivered to Texas (DDP)? Landed cost per unit?

Rough budget to launch (ballpark, before quotes)

Item	Rough cost
Trademark and LLC	$500–1,500
Tech packs (4 styles)	$1,000–2,500
Samples (2 rounds, 3 factories)	$1,500–4,000
First run (4 styles × ~150 units)	$10,000–25,000
Labels, tags, packaging	$1,000–2,000
Photography	$1,500–4,000
Shopify + fulfilment	about $100/month plus per-order fees

Pre-orders cover part of the production cost before the factory is paid.

Pricing

The concept site now shows USD launch prices as placeholders (10 Oct 2026): tee $58, shorts $64, quarter-zip $98, hoodie $108, cap $38, shaker $24, duffel $110. They sit just under Lululemon men's. Final prices come from the factory quotes: aim for the retail price to be at least **4× the landed cost per unit** to leave room for marketing, returns and discounts.